

1240 Kiev is captured by the Mongols.

1300s Poland captures Galicia while Lithuania expands eastward into the region; by 1386 Ukraine is part of the Lithuanian–Polish commonwealth.

1772, 1793 In the first two partitions of Poland, Galicia becomes part of Austria, Ukraine part of the Russian Empire.

1917 An independent Ukrainian republic is declared. The following year, Austrian Ukraine proclaims itself a republic and is federated with its Russian counterpart.

1919 The Red Army invades. Ukrainian Soviet Socialist Republic is proclaimed.

1920 Poland invades and western Ukraine comes under Polish occupation.

1922 Ukrainian SSR becomes one of the founder members of the USSR.

1922–30 Cultural revival under Lenin's "Ukrainianization" policy.

1932–33 Ukrainianization policy is reversed. Stalin collectivizes agriculture, inducing famine to eliminate Ukraine as source of opposition; seven million die.

1939 The USSR invades Poland after the Nazi–Soviet Pact and incorporates its ethnic Ukrainian territories into Ukraine.

1941 Germany invades the USSR. Roughly 7.5 million Ukrainians die by 1945.

1942 Nationalists form Ukrainian Insurgent army, which wages war against both Germans and Soviets.

1954 Russia cedes Crimea to Ukraine.

1972 Arrests of intellectuals and dissidents by Soviets, as Volodymyr Shcherbitsky, a hardline Brezhnevite, replaces reformer Petr Shelest as head of Communist Party of Ukraine (CPU).

1986 In the world's worst nuclear disaster, a reactor at Chernobyl explodes, sending a radioactive plume across Europe, but missing nearby Kiev.

1989 First major coalminers' strike in Donbass; pro-Gorbachev Volodymyr Ivashko heads CPU.

1990 Ukrainian parliament declares Ukrainian SSR a sovereign state.

1991 Ukraine declares full independence, a move approved in a referendum by 90 percent of voters. Leonid Kravchuk becomes president. The CPU is banned.

1993 Major strike in Donbass results in a costly settlement, which exacerbates the budget deficit and stimulates hyperinflation. The CPU is reestablished.

1994 Leonid Kuchma defeats Kravchuk to become first democratically elected president of Ukraine.

1996 New constitution comes into force.

1997 Friendship treaty signed with Russia. The accord allows the use of Ukrainian ports by Russia and division of the Black Sea fleet. A cooperation deal signed the following year.

1999 Kuchma reelected despite opposition claims of fraud.

2000 Chernobyl site closed.

2001 Growing protests after Kuchma is linked with the murder of journalist Georgiy Gongadze. Kuchma replaces the reformist government of Viktor Yushchenko after parliamentary defeat.

2004 Kuchma's chosen successor Viktor Yanukovich wins contested elections. Victor Yushchenko falls seriously ill and it is confirmed that he has been poisoned with dioxin. Mass protests in Kiev during the Orange Revolution lead to a revote in December and victory for Yushchenko.

2006 Yanukovich wins parliamentary elections and becomes prime minister. He clashes with Yushchenko on most policies.

2007 President Yushchenko attempts to dissolve parliament to force new elections, leading to constitutional crisis.

2009 Russia cuts off gas supplies to Ukraine for a week.

2010 Viktor Yanukovich wins run-off presidential election against prime minister Yuliya Tymoshenko (Viktor Yushchenko is eliminated in the first round). The Ukrainian parliament ratifies a 25-year extension of the Russian lease on the Black Sea bases.

◀138–39 Nomads of the Steppes
◀186–87 The Black Death

Belarus



Belarus—the name means “White Russia”—became independent only reluctantly in 1991.

900s–1100s CE Emergence of the principality of Polotsk on the territory of modern Belarus.

1324 The area is incorporated into the Grand Duchy of Lithuania. Minsk becomes an important commercial and cultural center.

1386 The Grand Duchy of Lithuania unites with Poland: Belorussia, as it was then known, becomes part of the Lithuanian–Polish commonwealth, participating in wars against the Teutonic Order, the Russians, the Tatars, and the Turks.

1772–95 The partition of Poland leads to the region being taken over by Russia.

1835 Nicholas I decrees that Minsk shall be a place where Jews can live.

1863 An uprising against Russian rule, led by Kastus Kalinowski, is put down and Kalinowski is executed.

1905 The Russian Revolution leads to a renewal of the Belorussian national movement. The revolutionary Hromada (community) Party demands autonomy for Belorussia, but wins little support.

1918 After the Bolshevik Revolution of 1917, the Belorussian Bolsheviks stage a coup and declare independence as the Belorussian Soviet Socialist Republic (BSSR). Germans occupy Minsk.

1919 Poland invades Belorussia.

1920 Minsk is retaken by the Red Army. Eastern Belorussia is reestablished as a Soviet Socialist Republic.

1921 Under the Treaty of Riga, Western Belorussia is incorporated into Poland.

1922 BSSR becomes part of USSR.

1929 Stalin implements collectivization of agriculture.

1939 Western Belorussia is reincorporated into the USSR when the Soviet Red Army invades Poland.

1941–44 Germany occupies Belarus, and over two million people, including most of the large Jewish population, die.

1965 K. T. Mazurau, Communist Party of Belorussia (PKB) leader, becomes first deputy chair of Soviet government.

1986 Radioactive fallout after Chernobyl affects 70 percent of country.

Protest at dictator's “reelection”

Demonstrators gather in Minsk in March 2006, demanding a fresh vote after hardline communist president Aleksandr Lukashenko won a landslide victory. The elections were widely condemned as rigged.

1988 Evidence is revealed of mass executions (over 300,000) by the Soviet military between 1937 and 1941 near Minsk: popular outrage fuels the formation of the nationalist Belarussian Popular Front (BPF).

1989 Belarussian is adopted as the republic's official language.

1990 PKB prevents BPF from participating in elections to Supreme Soviet. BPF members join other opposition groups in the Belarussian Democratic Bloc (BDB). After the BDB wins 25 percent of seats, the PKB bows to opposition pressure and issues the Declaration of the State Sovereignty of BSSR.

1991 Eighty-three percent vote in referendum to preserve union with USSR, but as the USSR falls apart, the country declares independence as the Republic of Belarus. Belarus, Russia, and Ukraine later establish the Commonwealth of Independent States.

1992 Supreme Soviet announces that Soviet nuclear weapons must be cleared from Belarus by 1999.

1993 Belarussian parliament ratifies nuclear nonproliferation treaties.

1994 A new presidential constitution is approved; Aleksandr Lukashenko defeats prime minister Vyacheslav Kebich in elections. Monetary union with Russia.

1995 First full-fledged post-Soviet parliament elected. Friendship and cooperation pact signed with Russia.

1996 Referendum approves constitutional changes, thereby strengthening Lukashenko's powers.

2000–01 In parliamentary elections Lukashenko wins again after a clampdown on PKB's political opponents.

2006 Lukashenko wins third term as president in a disputed election. Defeated candidate is jailed for “hooliganism.”

2008 The governing party wins all 110 seats in parliamentary elections.

◀186–87 The Black Death

